

The ADHD Community for Women on TikTok

Visibility, Commodification, and the Algorithm

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The question

TikTok has become one of the first places many women encounter language for their own ADHD — often before, or instead of, a clinical diagnosis. This piece asks: what happens to a mental health condition when the community that forms around it is shaped by a platform built to maximize engagement?

ADHD in women is historically under-diagnosed. Diagnostic criteria were built largely around male, hyperactive presentations; women more often present as inattentive, disorganized, or emotionally dysregulated — symptoms that are easier to dismiss or misattribute. A visible, peer-driven community filled a real gap. This paper asks what that community becomes once it's routed through an algorithm.

Method

A qualitative media-text analysis, examining:

- **Platform structure** — how TikTok's recommendation system distributes and reinforces certain content over others
- **Recurring aesthetics** — short-form formats like "signs you have ADHD" lists, rapid-cut "what my ADHD brain sounds like" videos, and meme-style explainers
- **Social function** — what these formats do for the people who make and watch them, beyond their surface content

Grounded in media theory: Bernard Dick's framework on how aesthetic choices shape meaning, Jesper Juul's argument that a system's rules shape the experiences possible within it, and Sonia Livingstone's work on platforms turning complex social issues into simplified, commercially useful narratives.

What the research found

1. Real validation, not just noise. Women describe genuine recognition seeing their own

experiences reflected — reframing things they'd internalized as personal failure (disorganization, "laziness," emotional volatility) as a recognized pattern. For a population that's faced diagnostic neglect, this is a meaningful function, not a trivial one.

2. The format compresses the diagnosis. The same short-form style that makes ADHD content accessible also rewards emotional immediacy over clinical accuracy. A 12-second "POV: your ADHD brain at 2am" video outperforms a careful explanation of diagnostic criteria — not because it's more true, but because it's more shareable. Complex, persistent, cross-context symptoms get flattened into relatable one-liners.

3. Commodification is structural, not incidental. Creators routinely move from personal disclosure straight into product marketing — planners, coaching, "ADHD brain" tools — inside the same video. The emotional trust built in the story is what makes the pitch work. This isn't a few bad actors; it's a predictable outcome of how engagement-optimized storytelling and monetization interact.

4. These effects coexist — they don't cancel out. A single video can validate a real experience, oversimplify the underlying condition, and sell a product, all at once. The paper's central claim is that this overlap *is* the phenomenon — not a contradiction to resolve, but the actual shape of what algorithmically-mediated mental health discourse looks like.

Why it matters for Social Algorithms

This is a case study in a platform's incentive structure doing more than distributing a discourse — it's reshaping what that discourse *becomes*. The ranking system doesn't neutrally carry this community's content: it rewards emotionally compressed, relatable formats over slower or more accurate ones, while creating exactly the conditions commercialization needs, since emotional trust built in a personal story increases the effectiveness of whatever follows it.

This is the same mechanism I built the [reply-incentive simulator](#) to demonstrate directly — change what a platform optimizes for, and you change which voices and framings rise to the top, even with identical underlying content. Here, that mechanism plays out with real stakes: how a historically underdiagnosed population understands its own condition. It suggests that incentive and moderation design aren't just abstract discourse-quality questions — they have direct downstream effects on health literacy and self-understanding for a specific, vulnerable group.

A note on scope

This was a critical media-text analysis for an undergraduate communications course — not an empirical study with original data collection (no surveys, interviews, or computational

content analysis of TikTok itself). It sits alongside the more hands-on, data-driven pieces in this portfolio as the analytical/theoretical counterpart: where the simulator and labeling study test mechanisms directly, this piece traces how those same mechanisms play out in a real, consequential case.

Full paper available on request / linked below.